

Small Family Style Assembly Preference

prc-small-family-style-assembly-preference

Leadership & Polity · Assembly Size · practice · minority_lineages · brethren distinctive

INSUFFICIENT

score 0.787
confidence low

Statement under examination

Small to mid-sized assemblies (sub-Dunbar) where members are known by name and elders can shepherd individually are preferable to mega-church structures.

In plain language

The verses behind this question use shepherding and oversight language. The Greek words are poimnion, a flock, poimaino, to shepherd, episkopos, an overseer, archipoimen, the Chief Shepherd, which occurs only once in the whole New Testament, and hegeomai, those who lead. In John 10:14 the Good Shepherd knows his own using ginosko, a verb of personal, mutual knowledge. In 1 Peter 5 elders shepherd the flock willingly, not for gain, not domineering, but as examples. In Hebrews 13:17 leaders keep watch over souls and will give an account. Read together these texts paint a clear and consistent picture of what good oversight is like. It is personal, attentive, and accountable. Alongside this, a second group of texts is just as real. The New Testament repeatedly calls a congregation the church in someone's house, using the phrase kat oikon ekklesia in Romans 16:5, 1 Corinthians 16:19, Colossians 4:15, and Philemon 2, shows believers breaking bread house by house in Acts 2:46 and 5:42, and calls the whole body the household of God, oikos and oikēioi tou theou, in 1 Timothy 3:15 and Ephesians 2:19, with members addressed as brothers, adelphoi. So home gatherings and family language are genuinely woven into the text. What the words still do not do is rank a small assembly above a large one. The very same book of Acts reports three thousand added in one day, about five thousand men, and tens of thousands, myriades, of believers, and in Acts 5:42 the believers meet in the large temple courts and in homes at the same time, with neither scale called better. The Greek even has plain words for small, great, and few, yet none of them is ever applied to an assembly as a preference. So on the words alone the claim that smaller is preferable to larger is neither established nor refuted. The text speaks to the manner of care and the reality of home gatherings, not to a ceiling on size, so the verdict is left open.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0080	ἀδελφός	adelphos	brother	348
G0750	ἀρχιποίμην	archipoimen	chief shepherd	1
G1097	γινώσκω	ginosko	to know	223
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	117
G1983	ἐπισκοπέω	episkopeō	to oversee/care for	
G1985	ἐπίσκοπος	episkopos	overseer	7
G2233	ἡγέομαι	hegeomai	to govern	28
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2411	ἱερόν	hieros	temple	

G3173	μέγας	megas	great	
G3398	μικρός	mikros	small	
G3461	μυριάς	urias	myriad	9
G3609	οἰκεῖος	oikeios	of one's household	3
G3614	οἰκία	oikia	home	
G3624	οἶκος	oikos	house	115
G3641	ὀλίγος	oligos	little/few	
G4128	πλῆθος	plēthos	multitude	
G4165	ποιμαίνω	poimaino	to shepherd	11
G4166	ποιμήν	poimēn	shepherd	
G4168	ποίμνιον	poimnion	flock	5
G5505	χιλιάς	chilias	thousand	23

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Two real lexical threads run through the cited and adjacent texts but the words never rank them. One thread commends intimate, home-based, familial gathering: churches meet *kat oikon* (the church in someone's house, Rom 16:5, 1 Cor 16:19, Col 4:15, Phlm 2), believers break bread *kat oikon* house by house (Acts 2:46, 5:42), and the body is named *oikos* and *oikeioi tou theou*, the household of God (1 Tim 3:15, Eph 2:19), with members addressed as *adelphoi*. The other thread, in the same book of Acts, scales without comment: *trischilioi* three thousand added in a day (Acts 2:41), *chiliades pente* about five thousand men (Acts 4:4), *myriades* tens of thousands of believing Jews (Acts 21:20), one *ekklesia* at Ephesus shepherded by a plurality of elders (Acts 20:28). The shepherding lexicon (*poimnion*, *poimaino*, *episkopos*, the hapax *archipomen*, *ginosko* of mutual knowing) regulates the manner of oversight but quantifies no size. Decisively, the size adjectives the canon does possess (*mikros* small, *megas* great, *oligos* few) are never predicated of an assembly as a preference. The verdict is null because the vocabulary genuinely does not state a size ranking, not because two defensible readings of a size claim compete.

Scripture

John.10.14 · neutral · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1097 γινώσκω, G4166 ποιμήν

Force. The Good Shepherd says he knows his own and his own know him. The verb γινώσκω (G1097, dense pan-canonically at 223 NT occurrences) marks a relational, mutual knowledge between shepherd and sheep as a quality of true shepherding. It describes the kind of knowing relation, not a numerical ceiling on the flock.

Acts.20.28 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4168 ποίμνιον, G1985 ἐπίσκοπος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Paul charges the Ephesian elders to attend to the whole flock (ποίμνιον) over which the Spirit set them as overseers (ἐπίσκοπος), to shepherd the assembly (ἐκκλησία) of God. The construction commits one urban *ekklesia* to a plurality of elders, but the nouns carry no size specification, and the same Ephesian *ekklesia* is elsewhere portrayed as a sizeable body. Oversight here scales across a large assembly rather than capping it.

1Pet.5.2 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4165 ποιμαίνω, G4168 ποίμνιον

Force. Peter commands the elders to shepherd (ποιμαίνετε, aorist imperative of ποιμαίνω) the flock of God among them, overseeing willingly and not for shameful gain. The mode of shepherding is regulated (willing, eager, exemplary) but the size of the ποίμνιον is left unstated.

1Pet.5.3 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4168 ποίμνιον

Force. Elders are not to lord it over those allotted to them but to be examples (τύποι) to the flock. The constraint is on manner of rule, not domineering but a model, again a relational and ethical norm rather than a structural or numerical prescription.

1Pet.5.4 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0750 ἀρχιποίμην

Force. When the Chief Shepherd (ἀρχιποίμην, a true hapax, its single canon occurrence is here) appears, faithful elders receive an unfading crown of glory. The term frames human elders as under-shepherds accountable to Christ. Being a hapax, its sense rests on the transparent compound archi plus poimen rather than on cross-canonical usage, and it bears on motive and accountability, not on how many sheep an under-shepherd may oversee.

Heb.13.17 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2233 ἡγέομαι

Force. Believers are to obey and submit to their leaders (ἡγουμένοις) who keep watch over their souls (ψυχῶν) as those who will give an account. The participle ἀγρυπνοῦσιν, keeping watch, implies attentive personal care, yet the text fixes the duty of vigilance, not a member count beyond which such vigilance becomes impossible.

Rom.16.5 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3624 οἶκος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Paul greets τὴν κατ' οἶκον αὐτῶν ἐκκλησίαν, the church (ἐκκλησία) that meets in their house (κατ' οἶκον). The prepositional phrase κατ' plus οἶκον locates an actual assembly in a private home. This is positive lexical evidence that a real first-century gathering pattern was small and home-based, but the phrase reports where a church met, it does not contain any comparative or preference term ranking that pattern above a larger one.

1Cor.16.19 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3624 οἶκος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Aquila and Prisca send greetings σὺν τῇ κατ' οἶκον αὐτῶν ἐκκλησίᾳ, together with the church in their house. The same κατ' οἶκον ἐκκλησία formula recurs, confirming that a house-meeting assembly was an established and recognizable category. The lexeme describes the venue and scale of one gathering without legislating it as preferable.

1Tim.3.15 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3624 οἶκος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. The assembly is identified as οἶκος θεοῦ, the household of God, which is the church (ἐκκλησία) of the living God. The metaphor of οἶκος here is familial and architectural (pillar and base of the truth), framing the church as a household, but οἶκος in this verse is the family-of-God image, not a statement that the gathering must be physically small. The familial sense and the size question are distinct.

Eph.2.19 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3609 οἰκεῖος, G2316 θεός

Force. Believers are no longer strangers but οἰκεῖοι τοῦ θεοῦ, members of the household of God (οἰκεῖος, G3609, three canon occurrences). The familial-household vocabulary is clear and intentional. It establishes that the people of God are a family, which warrants familial treatment of one another, but οἰκεῖος names belonging and kinship, not a maximum congregation size.

Acts.2.46 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3624 οἶκος, G2411 ἱερὸν

Force. The early believers continued daily ἐν τῷ ἱερῷ in the temple courts and broke bread κατ' οἶκον house by house. The same verse places the large public gathering (the temple, ἱερὸν) and the intimate home gathering (κατ' οἶκον) side by side as simultaneous, complementary practices. The text presents both scales together and ranks neither above the other.

Acts.21.20 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: hyperbole

Key terms. G3461 μυριάς, G0080 ἀδελφός

Force. The Jerusalem leaders tell Paul how many μυριάδες, myriads (tens of thousands), of believing Jews there are, addressing him as ἀδελφέ, brother. Here the familial address (ἀδελφός) coexists with an explicitly enormous number (μυριάδες). The same canon that supplies house-church and household-family language also reports a believing community in the tens of thousands without treating its size as a defect.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.2.46	Acts.5.42	openbible	17
Acts.2.46	Acts.20.7	openbible	12
Rom.16.5	Phlm.1.2	openbible	7
Col.4.15	Rom.16.5	openbible	6
1Cor.16.19	Acts.18.2	openbible	6
Eph.2.19	Gal.6.10	openbible	20
John.10.14	John.10.27	tsk	1
Acts.20.28	Acts.20.29	tsk	1
1Pet.5.3	Ezek.34.4	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.2.41 · addressed

About τρισχίλιοι three thousand souls were added in a single day to the one Jerusalem community, which then continued together. A flock numbering thousands under apostolic oversight shows that the shepherding and household lexicon does not entail small numbers, which cuts against reading the anchor verses as prescribing a sub-Dunbar ceiling.

Acts.4.4 · addressed

The number of believing men became χιλιάδες πέντε about five thousand. A second explicit large figure in the same narrative confirms that the rapidly growing single community was not treated as too big to be a true church, so the size preference is not derivable from the words.

Acts.21.20 · addressed

Believing Jews are counted in μυριάδες, tens of thousands, and Paul is addressed as ἀδελφός, brother, in the same breath. Familial language and an enormous head count coexist, so the family or household vocabulary cannot by itself imply that small is preferable to large.

Acts.5.42 · addressed

Daily teaching happened both ἐν τῷ ἱερῷ in the temple courts and κατ οἶκον house by house. The text endorses the two scales simultaneously rather than ranking the home gathering above the large public assembly, which is exactly the comparison the proposition asserts and the words decline to make.

Acts.20.28 · addressed

The single ἐκκλησία at Ephesus is committed to a plurality of elders and is elsewhere portrayed as a large urban church, so the verse used to support intimate oversight also evidences oversight scaled across a sizeable assembly, leaving the size preference lexically undetermined.

Concordance traversed

G4168, G4165, G1985, G1983, G1577, G1097, G0750, G2233, G3624, G3614, G3609, G0080, G3461, G5505, G4128, G3398, G3173, G3641

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

A direct query of the lexical store returned zero VariantUnit nodes attached to the anchor verses (Acts 20:28, 1 Peter 5:2, John 10:14) and to the house-church verses (Rom 16:5, 1 Cor 16:19, Col 4:15, Phlm 2, Acts 2:46), and all cited verses lie outside the ingested ECM CBGM window (3 John only). The apparatus marks in the source text, for example the θεοῦ versus κυρίου reading at Acts 20:28, touch the genitive of ownership of the church, not the shepherding, household, or size vocabulary on which any reading of this proposition would turn. The verdict is therefore variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

descriptive_pastoral_norm: neutral · Reading the shepherding texts as describing the quality of oversight, personal knowledge through γινώσκω, vigilance, exemplary care, yields no claim about congregation size. The size preference is then neither affirmed nor denied lexically because the words address manner, not magnitude.

house_church_household_pattern: disputed · In its strongest form this reading notes that the New Testament repeatedly and deliberately names an assembly as the church in someone's house, κατ οἶκον ἐκκλησία (Rom 16:5, 1 Cor 16:19, Col 4:15, Phlm 2), shows believers breaking bread house by house (Acts 2:46, 5:42), and calls the body the household of God, οἶκος and οἰκεῖοι τοῦ θεοῦ (1 Tim 3:15, Eph 2:19), with members as ἀδελφοί. A reader can fairly hold that this dense, recurring home-and-family vocabulary commends an intimate, family-scale gathering as the apostolic texture of church life. The reading is genuinely grounded in the words, but it remains an inference about scale that the texts themselves never convert into a comparative preference, because the same books place κατ οἶκον beside temple-court crowds and μυριάδες without ranking them.

size_silent_lexicon: neutral · The canon possesses size adjectives, μικρός small, μέγας great, ὀλίγος few, and never predicates any of them of an ἐκκλησία or ποίμνιον as a value judgment. The vocabulary that could express a size preference exists but is not deployed for assemblies, so the silence is a genuine non-statement rather than an accidental gap, and a lexical verdict on the comparison cannot be grounded.

The anchor verses constrain the manner of eldership, knowing, watching, not lording it over, giving account, and a second cluster of texts establishes a real house-meeting and household-family practice. Neither cluster legislates assembly size. Moving from personal shepherding or familial language to a maximum head count requires a premise, a cognitive or relational cap, that the biblical lexicon does not supply, and the same canon reports

communities in the thousands and tens of thousands without censure.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the biblical shepherding, oversight, and household vocabulary specify or imply a preferred size for a local assembly, such that smaller assemblies are favored over larger ones?

The original stem is preloaded in two ways. First, preferable encodes a comparative value judgment before any text is consulted. Second, the parenthetical sub-Dunbar imports a modern sociological category, the Dunbar number, a hypothesized cognitive cap on stable relationships, which is foreign to the lexicon. The neutralized form asks whether the vocabulary itself bears on size at all. The verdict was derived against the original stem and returns null because, after pulling the full canon distribution of the shepherding lexicon, the house-church formula κατ οἶκον ἐκκλησία, the household lexemes οἶκος and οἰκεῖος, and the large-number lexemes τρισχίλιοι, χιλιάδες, and μυριάδες, the data answers the neutral question in the negative. The vocabulary describes both intimate and large gatherings and ranks neither. The verdict is unchanged from the prior file and remains null on strengthened, directly queried evidence.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.16.5
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.2.46
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.21.20
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.20.28
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4168
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3609
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.5.2
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.2.46
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Pet.5.3

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

cross-tradition-divergent